

Zephyrus

The gearshift is drenched. Blood is dripping down his arm. He doesn't mind, all that's on his mind is speed and getting this car to its destination. The world is dark and hazy, the fog painted with a deep violet as Z whips the car around a corner. His eyes flick to the rear view mirror. Nothing. His windshield is dotted with snow. Shades of obsidian shimmer as he speeds down a luminous alleyway. He's almost there, he glances at his watch, it's cracked and covered in crimson. He shakes his wrist in pain as he tries to wipe it on his shirt. It leaves a dark smear on his navy blue shirt, but he can read it. The watch reads 2:48. He lets the back of his head fall against the headrest on the seat as he takes a big breath of air. He returns the speed of the car back to the speed limit as he makes his way to the client who hired him. He cruises down the snow dusted street, the amethyst glow catching his eye. He admires the colors as he drives. Z slowly pulls into a car shop parking lot and cracks the door. As he moves to get out he slips on the snow

"Fucking snow." He stumbles, world tilting for a heartbeat. As he walks to the entrance blood blooms across the snow in dark petals. The purple reflects off the frosted handle as he grips it. As he steps into the shop Titan, a tall, muscular, and heavily modded man approaches him, greeting him with a loose hug with no mind of the blood.

"You get the payload?" Titan asks with an almost admirable look in his eye.

"It's out front" Z nods. Z makes his way to the couch and flops on it. He hears familiar footsteps approaching, he knows what she is gonna say already.

"Get your damn blood off the couch Z." Alyssa says with a glint in her eye.

"Will do" Z says.

Titan steps back in a side door. "Moved it to the garage" he says as he sets the key on the counter.

"You will get your pay tomorrow when they come to pick it up. For now, go to the hospital. Please?" Titan says.

Z side-eyes Titan. "What's wrong? It's just a small cut."

He pulls his jacket away, and his stomach twists. The cut is larger than he expected, dark and jagged against his skin. Shapes tilt, colors smear, and the room seems to

breathe around him. His vision narrows, then rolls upward, and he collapses onto the couch, the edges of the world bending and stretching.

Z jolts awake and a strong hand shakes his shoulder. "Zephyr Wake up".

Z looks up at the person shaking his shoulder recognizing the familiar face immediately. It was Tec, his partner. Z stretches his arms out above his head and yawns.

"How long was I out for?" Z asks sleepily.

"Judging by that red block on your face, at least an hour" says Tec.

Z feels something is off. This was home but also unfamiliar, why? He runs his hand across the desk feeling the scratches and bumps, he stops at a particularly deep scratch.

"I remember that case, the client was like demonspawn remember" Tec says with a chuckle.

"Oh trust me, I remember. That big ass knife was hard to forget, even the desk remembers" Z says laughing with Tec.

A terrible bang echos through the room. Z jumps out of his seat. Ears ringing, and disoriented, Z slams his hands against the sides of his face covering his ears. When he glances back up at Tec, his face is unsettling. It looks painful, frozen, horribly out of place. But he recognized it. He had seen Tec make this face once before. Where, where had he seen it? Zephyr's mind is racing and Tec falls forward gravity consuming his weight. His head hits the desk with a hard and skull crunching sound. Zephyr covers his eyes and immediately bursts into tears, wailing. He had seen that face once before. When he was shot in the back of the head. The image had played in his mind countless times over the last 3 years. It haunted his dreams. Watching his best friend and partner die over and over again. Shot by the very people he trusted.

Z jolts awake in a hospital bed. His head is pounding and he is covered in cold sweat. He tries to reach around to hug himself but only one arm comes across his body, as he looks down to his left side, there are only bandages. No arm. And he just sits quietly. Confused, afraid, and alone. Z stares out the window at the falling snow. Never had it been so pretty before, the white flakes with a grey backdrop. Falling from the sky in big clusters, the snow layered the ground. Snow was so beautiful, almost like a cocoon for the earth. Hides so much away, and when it all melts, it's like a different world. But snow is cold and stays around here forever. It's hard to love. Kind of like myself. Z catches

himself in his mind again. He reaches across the bed and his hand finds the cold white plastic button, he squeezes it and closes his eyes again. But not to sleep, he was too scared for that. But to process reality now that he was back.

Illusions

Z hears footsteps approach the door. He looks at the crack underneath, and then to the handle. The door slowly swings open to reveal a young man holding a clipboard.

"You called?" the young man asks

With a bit of force in his voice Z says "I did, what's happening? How did I get here?"

The young man looks at him with saddened eyes. "You were dropped off in the lobby a week ago. The people who dropped you off left before we could ask any questions. We rushed you to an emergency room where we examined your left arm. It had sustained quite a large amount of damage and had destroyed many critical vessels and ligaments in your left arm. If they didn't remove it, they wouldn't have been able to repair it. I am sorry for your loss, but we had to amputate your arm. The damages were too great to repair."

"Oh... I see" Z says, looking out the window. He had stopped listening half way through. He just wanted to watch the snow.

"Can I get some information from you sir? We tried to read your ID chip, but it was hashed and had a lock so we were unable to retrieve anything" the young man says

"Sure, ask away" Z says as he goes deeper into his covers.

"Name?" the man asks.

"Z, short for Zephyrus"

"And your last name?"

"Synch" Z says quietly.

"Occupation?" He reads off his clipboard.

"Detective." he says slightly dazed. "No, sorry I am currently unemployed." Z says trying to get it over with.

"Insurance?" the man says awkwardly.

“Can we do this later? A lot is happening” Z says, retreating.

“Sure, no worries. I will have food up around dinner time, and we can bring in our Mod Doc to discuss prosthetics if you would like.” the man says standing up and turning to the door.

“Sure, can he come around dinner as well then?” Z says a bit more confidently.

“Yes, I will have him come up right after dinner.” The man says with a bit happier voice than he has had.

“Thank you” Z says as the young man exits, closing the door behind him.

A prosthetic? My arm is gone? What a cruel world. And I had that dream again right before. Hell is real, and it's on this earth. Why do humans keep fighting? Why do we hold on? Why do I miss my arm? I need money for a prosthetic. Wait, the car. I wonder if Titan put my deposit in. that should cover a mid to high grade arm.

A sharp stinging pain hits Z's left shoulder, his arm instinctively reaches for it, but he stops just as he is about to rub his new mound of an arm. Fuck, thats the only way to describe how I feel right now.

Z glanced around his bed, where he found another button, this one was red and it definitely wasn't the call button. His relief was almost immediate and he felt morphine rush into his system, it was all too relaxing. Z's eyes started to feel heavy as he drifted off into a nap.

When he awoke again, the door was in the process of being opened. The young man was back with a tray of food. The food looked like it was cooked in the cafeteria of a hospital. Almost like airplane food without the fancy bamboo utensils. Z accepted the food as the young man placed it on his lap for him. Z picked up his fork. And slowly cut into the meatloaf on the plate. It was easy to cut with one hand. He carefully ate. His right arm feels more awkward without its left counterpart. As Z finished eating, the young man picked up the tray and began to head out.

Just as he was leaving the young man said “ill send the Mod Doc up.”

Z didn't say a single word. Nothing the whole time. He just laid back, waiting for the inevitable.

"How are we feeling today?" a warm voice asks.

Z looks over to find a middle aged man with a graying beard and long hair. Z read his name tag as dr.Pell.

"I am doing my best here, it's not everyday you lose an arm you know?" Z says with dry humor.

"Yep, I totally understand. But let's get to business so you don't have to feel armless forever. So let's start with the budget. How much are you looking to spend on this mod?"

Z shifted beneath the sheets. "These are mainstream prosthetics. Expensive, right?"

The Mod Doc's eyes drifted away from him. "They can be. But they're done clean. Regulated. And we put you under for installation."

Z yawned. "What if I brought my own? Aftermarket. Military."

That got his attention.

"How much would the procedure cost?" Z asked.

The Mod Doc didn't answer right away. "You'd be flagged in our system," he said finally. "We don't sedate for aftermarket or non-essential applications. And if it's not installed before discharge, it stops being classified as necessary."

He met Z's eyes. "That's the choice."